

(1370–1352 BCE). In ancient Egypt, the nutritionally valuable seeds were eaten and also pressed to yield oil, which was burned in lamps and used to make ointments. Sesame has long been considered to have magical powers, and the phrase “Open sesame!”, from the *Arabian Nights*, remains a well-known magical command. The Middle Eastern confection halvah is made from crushed and sweetened sesame seeds.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Sesame is principally used as a food and flavoring agent in China, but it is also taken to redress “states of deficiency,” especially those affecting the liver and kidneys. The seeds are prescribed for problems such as dizziness, tinnitus (ringing in the ears), and blurred vision (when due to anemia). Owing to their lubricating effect within the digestive tract, the seeds are also considered a remedy for “dry” constipation. The seeds have a marked ability to stimulate the production of breast milk. Sesame seed oil benefits the skin and is used as a base for cosmetics. It can be used to treat fungal skin problems such as athlete’s foot.

Research Research suggests that sesame seeds have antibacterial and antifungal activity. They also lower cholesterol and support levels of “good cholesterol” (HDL).

Smilax spp. (Liliaceae) Sarsaparilla

Description Perennial woody climber growing to 16 ft (5 m). Has broadly ovate leaves, tendrils, and small greenish flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Sarsaparilla species are found in tropical rainforests and in temperate regions in Asia and Australia. The root is gathered throughout the year.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Sarsaparilla contains 1–3% steroidal saponins, phytosterols (including beta- and e-sitosterol), about 50% starch, resin, sarsapic acid, and minerals. Despite the herb’s reputation for being testosterone, the steroidal saponins and sterols are estrogenic and anti-inflammatory. The saponins also have antibiotic activity.

History & Folklore Brought from the New World to Spain in 1563, sarsaparilla was heralded as a cure for syphilis, reportedly having been used in the Caribbean with some success. The claims, however, were grossly inflated and the herb’s popularity soon waned. In Mexico, sarsaparilla has traditionally been used to treat a variety of skin problems. Before it was replaced by artificial agents, sarsaparilla root was the original flavoring for root beer.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Sarsaparilla is anti-inflammatory and cleansing, and the herb can bring relief to skin problems such as eczema, psoriasis, and general itchiness, and help treat rheumatism, rheumatoid arthritis, and gout. Its estrogenic action makes it beneficial in premenstrual problems, and menopausal conditions such as debility and depression. Native Amazonian peoples take sarsaparilla to improve virility and to treat menopausal problems. In Mexico, the root is still frequently consumed for its reputed tonic and aphrodisiac properties.

Research Some of the steroidal saponins have been shown to bind to toxins within the gut, reducing their absorption into the bloodstream. This may account for sarsaparilla’s usefulness in autoimmune conditions such as psoriasis, rheumatoid arthritis, and ulcerative colitis, which can be associated with this sort of toxicity. Clinical research in China suggests that sarsaparilla might hold potential in the treatment of leptospirosis, a rare disease transmitted to humans by rats, and the acute stage of syphilis.

Solanum dulcamara (Solanaceae) Common Nightshade

Description Slender-stemmed, woody climber growing to 13 ft (4 m). Has deeply lobed oval leaves, dark purple flowers with yellow anthers, and scarlet oval berries.



Common nightshade treats skin problems and bronchitis.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, North Africa, and northern Asia, this herb has been naturalized in North America. A common wayside plant, it flourishes in open areas. The twigs are collected in spring or autumn, and the root bark in autumn.

Parts Used Twigs, root bark.

Constituents Common nightshade contains steroidal alkaloids (including solasodine and soldulcamaridine), steroidal saponins, and about 10% tannins.

History & Folklore The Swedish botanist Carolus Linnaeus (1707–1778) considered the herb to be a valuable remedy for fever and inflammatory disorders. The herb is also called bittersweet, perhaps referring to the initial bitter taste of the berries, followed by a sweet aftertaste.

Medicinal Actions & Uses This plant has stimulant, expectorant, diuretic, detoxifying, and antirheumatic properties. It appears to be most effective taken internally to treat skin problems such as eczema, itchiness, psoriasis, and warts. A decoction of the twigs, applied as a wash, may also help to lessen the severity of these conditions. The herb may also be taken to relieve asthma, chronic bronchitis, and rheumatic conditions, including gout.

Caution Common nightshade is toxic in excess. Take only under professional supervision.

Solanum melongena (Solanaceae) Eggplant, Aubergine

Description An erect, herbaceous perennial growing to 28 in (70 cm). Has slightly woolly leaves, violet flowers, and large purple fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to India and Southeast Asia, the eggplant is now cultivated in many tropical areas and also grown under glass in cooler climates. The fruit is gathered when ripe in summer or autumn.

Parts Used Fruit, fruit juice, leaves.

Constituents Eggplant contains proteins, carbohydrates, and vitamins A, B₁, B₂, and C.

History & Folklore Eggplant has been cultivated as a food in southern and eastern Asia since ancient times.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Eggplant fruit helps to lower blood cholesterol levels and is suitable as part of a diet to help regulate high blood pressure. The fruit can be applied fresh as a poultice for hemorrhoids, but it is more commonly used in the form of an oil or ointment. The fruit and its juice are effective diuretics. A soothing, emollient poultice for the treatment of burns, abscesses, cold sores, and similar conditions